Grit + Grace Doula

FREE FAMILY EDUCATION · GUIDE 05

The Fourth Trimester

Your Postpartum Recovery & Support Plan

A thoughtful plan for recovery space, practical help, emotional check-ins, follow-up care, and support over the first six weeks and beyond.

Printable workbook · US Letter

GUIDE 05 · 01

Recovery deserves a plan

Birth and recovery look different for every person. This guide helps you organize support, not predict how you will feel or how quickly recovery will unfold. Keep your own clinician's discharge instructions close.

Urgent maternal warning signs

Serious complications can occur during pregnancy and up to one year after birth. Seek immediate medical care for urgent symptoms such as severe headache that will not go away, vision changes, trouble breathing, chest pain or a fast heartbeat, fever of 100.4°F (38°C) or higher, heavy bleeding, severe abdominal pain, one-sided leg swelling or pain, or thoughts of harming yourself or your baby. This list is not complete. For a life-threatening emergency call 911.

A NOTE FROM TEESEE

A Note from Teesee: A prepared support circle can make it easier to ask for practical help while you focus on recovery and your family.

GUIDE 05 · 02

Build a recovery station

Recovery station checklist

- [ ] Comfort and personal care items
- [ ] Water and easy snacks
- [ ] Phone and charger
- [ ] Baby-care essentials within reach
- [ ] Care-team and emergency contacts
- [ ] Other item recommended by clinician

Set up a comfortable place to rest and feed or hold baby. Follow your clinician's guidance for wound care, activity, pain medicines, and any restrictions. Do not use this workbook to change a care plan.

GUIDE 05 · 03

Delegate household tasks

Specific offers can be easier to accept than a general offer to help. Choose what feels useful and assign a backup person where possible.

Household delegation plan

Task	First choice
Backup	Day/time
How to hand off	

Checklist

- [ ] Meals and groceries
- [ ] Laundry and dishes
- [ ] Older children or pets
- [ ] Transportation to appointments
- [ ] Visitor communication
- [ ] A protected rest period

GUIDE 05 · 04

Visitors and boundaries

Visitor boundaries

Who is welcome	Preferred visiting hours
How to ask before visiting	Helpful tasks visitors can do
How to pause or end a visit	Person who can communicate boundaries

Families can change visitor plans at any time. A quiet recovery period is a valid preference; no explanation is required.

Reflection

What would help me feel safe, respected, and rested at home?

GUIDE 05 · 05

Emotional wellbeing and check-ins

Many kinds of feelings can arise after birth. Tell someone you trust and your healthcare professional how you are doing, especially if distress feels intense, persistent, or frightening. Ask for help early; you do not have to wait until a scheduled visit.

Emotional check-in

Today I feel...

What feels hardest?

What has helped?

Who can I tell?

When will I check in again?

Immediate safety

If you may harm yourself or someone else, or cannot stay safe, call or text 988 in the U.S. or contact emergency services. For medical emergencies, call 911.

GUIDE 05 · 06

Healthcare follow-up

Arrange postpartum care with your obstetric or midwifery team and follow your discharge instructions. ACOG recommends initial contact with an obstetric care provider within the first 3 weeks postpartum and a comprehensive postpartum visit no later than 12 weeks; individual care needs may call for earlier or additional visits.

Follow-up planner

Provider/contact	Appointment date
Questions or symptoms to discuss	How to reach the office between visits
Other recommended follow-up	

Do not wait for a routine visit

Contact a healthcare professional promptly about a new or worsening symptom or an urgent warning sign.

GUIDE 05 · 07

Know urgent warning signs

Get immediate medical care for warning signs such as

- A severe headache that does not go away or gets worse
- Vision changes, fainting, or dizziness
- Trouble breathing, chest pain, or a fast-beating heart
- Fever of 100.4°F (38°C) or higher
- Heavy vaginal bleeding or discharge with a bad smell
- Severe belly pain, or one-sided leg swelling, redness, or pain
- Thoughts of harming yourself or your baby

This is a brief reminder, not a complete symptom guide. Tell the clinician you are pregnant or gave birth within the past year. If you feel something is seriously wrong, seek care even if the symptom is not listed.

My support contacts

Obstetric/midwifery team

Primary care clinician

Trusted support person

Local urgent care/emergency plan

988 call or text (U.S.)

GUIDE 05 · 08

The first two weeks

Plan for frequent practical help and a low-pressure rhythm. Recovery, feeding, and sleep needs vary. Follow your clinicians' instructions and ask for help with food, transport, chores, and baby care.

Weekly recovery plan: days 1–14

Support person and time	Meals/household task
Rest or recovery priority	Appointment or call
What changed/what I need	

GUIDE 05 · 09

Weeks three through six and beyond

Support often changes over time. Keep follow-up care on the calendar and revisit household plans as energy, feeding, and family needs change. Recovery is individual; ask your healthcare professional before resuming activities covered by your care instructions.

Weekly recovery plan: week 3 onward

What is improving?

What is still hard?

Who can help this week?

Healthcare follow-up

One boundary or task to adjust

GUIDE 05 · 10

You do not have to carry everything alone

Reflection

One clear request I can make this week is...

Optional reflection · Matthew 11:28

A reference for readers who welcome Christian encouragement; receiving support is an invitation, not a test of faith.

Sources and further reading

Urgent Maternal Warning Signs
Centers for Disease Control and Prevention — Hear Her

Optimizing Postpartum Care
American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists

My Postpartum Care Checklist
American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists

Educational information reviewed against these sources on October 14, 2026. Confirm current guidance with your qualified care team.

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